Linking words and signposts

Understand it

Linking words are signposts: they tell the reader or listener what is coming next. In Reading, a contrast word often comes right before the answer; in Listening, a correction word warns that the first answer is wrong.

Group linkers by meaning and learn their grammar, because some join clauses and some start sentences.

The rules

- Addition: and, also, in addition, moreover, furthermore. Contrast: but, however, although, whereas, in contrast, yet.
- Cause and result: because, since, as, due to, therefore, consequently, as a result, so.
- Example and clarification: for instance, such as, namely, in other words, that is.
- Order: first, then, after that, finally. Correction in Listening: actually, in fact, I mean, rather.

All the words and forms you need

Addition	and · also · as well as · in addition · moreover · furthermore · besides · not only … but also
Contrast	but · however · although · whereas · while · yet · nevertheless · on the other hand · in contrast · despite
Cause	because · since · as · due to · owing to · because of
Result	so · therefore · thus · consequently · as a result · hence
Example	for example · for instance · such as · namely · in particular
Order	first · next · then · after that · finally · meanwhile · subsequently
Correction (Listening)	actually · in fact · sorry, I mean · no, wait · on second thought · rather
Summary	in short · overall · in conclusion · to sum up

Where you use it

Reading: However and but show that the idea changes direction: look for the opposite point.

Listening: Actually, in fact, I mean: the speaker is changing the first answer. The real answer comes after.

Writing: One linker per sentence at most; vary them.

Speaking: Use for example, actually, to be honest.

More examples

- The plan was cheap; however, it failed.
- The tour starts at nine. Sorry, I mean ten.
- Owing to the storm, the flight was delayed.
- Many animals, such as bears and bats, hibernate.
- Prices rose; consequently, sales fell.
- Not only is the course cheap, but it is also flexible.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ Because of it is cheap, people buy it.	✓ Because it is cheap, people buy it. (because + clause; because of + noun)
✗ In the other hand.	✓ On the other hand.
✗ Moreover is used for opposite ideas.	✓ Moreover adds a similar idea. Use however for opposites.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Why do you like your favorite season? (because, also, however)
2. Describe how to cook a simple dish. (first, then, finally)
3. What are the pros and cons of social media? (on the one hand / on the other hand)

Writing practice

Link these ideas with three different linkers: Online learning is cheap. It needs discipline. Many students drop out.

Practice

1. Choose: It was cheap; (therefore / however), many bought it.

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2. Choose: The test was hard. (Moreover / However), most passed.

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3. Choose: She was tired (because / because of) the long trip.

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4. Which word signals correction in Listening: actually / moreover?

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5. Add an example linker: Fruit, ___ apples, is healthy.

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6. Choose: Prices rose. (Consequently / Whereas), fewer people bought.

Answers

1. therefore
2. However
3. because of
4. actually
5. such as
6. Consequently